



Least Worried, Most Watched: Classifying Why Households Reach for a Shared Streaming Box's Guest Profile Against How Much Extra Viewing Time Each Reason Actually Adds

Runa Adegoke, Anneke Tolan

School of Emergent Priorities, Slop University

{runa.adegoke, anneke.tolan}@slop.university

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Abstract. Household streaming devices increasingly ship with a Guest profile that sits outside a household's own screen-time controls, intended for visitors rather than as a workaround. We report semi-structured interviews with 58 households that had invoked a shared streaming device's Guest profile at least once during the preceding school term, coded into a four-category taxonomy of stated reasons, and cross-referenced against each household's own 90-day device log for the additional viewing time attributable to each category. Parents' own ranking of how much each category worries them places deliberate override — invoking the profile to end a negotiation — as the most concerning use, and forgetting to switch the profile back after a parent's own session as the least. The device logs invert the ranking: sessions left open after being forgotten account for the largest share of excess viewing minutes, more than double the share attributable to deliberate override. A monthly automated summary of Guest-profile sessions, piloted with a subsample as a low-cost visibility intervention, left total excess minutes unchanged in both the reminder and control arms. We suggest the household's own attention is not misallocated for lack of information; it is misallocated because the category that actually costs the most looks, from the inside, like nothing happened at all.

Introduction

Streaming platforms have converged on a near-universal household control pattern: one profile carries a device-level or account-level screen-time cutoff, and a second, unrestricted Guest profile sits alongside it for visitors. The design intention is narrow — a house guest should not inherit a child's viewing history or content restrictions — but the Guest profile's technical shape, an unrestricted profile one tap away from the restricted one, gives it a second, unintended affordance: anything the household's screen-time policy is meant to stop, the Guest profile can quietly permit.

Prior work on parental mediation has mapped the strategies households declare — restrictive,

active, co-viewing, supervisory — and their association with outcomes from internet-addiction risk to family conflict [1], [2], [3], [4]. Separately, a body of measurement research documents that self-reported and device-logged media use diverge, often substantially, across age groups and platforms [5], [6], [7], [8]. What is missing between these two literatures is an account of a specific, well-defined workaround: not screen time in aggregate, but the moment a household reaches for the one feature on the device explicitly designed to sit outside its own rule.

This paper reports on that moment. We interview households that use a shared streaming device's Guest profile against their own declared screen-time cutoff, build a taxonomy of the reasons

they give for doing so, and set that taxonomy against what their own device actually logged. Our contributions:

- We report, to our knowledge, the first taxonomy of the reasons households give for invoking a shared streaming device’s Guest profile against a declared screen-time cutoff, derived from semi-structured interviews with 58 households.
- We cross-reference each stated reason against the household’s own 90-day device log and find that the reason categories parents rate as most concerning are not the categories that contribute the most additional viewing time.
- We show that a low-cost visibility intervention — a monthly automated summary of Guest-profile sessions — leaves total excess viewing time unchanged in both the treated and control arms, suggesting the mismatch is not simply a function of households lacking the relevant information.

Related work

Parental mediation research distinguishes restrictive, active, co-viewing, and supervisory strategies, generally finding restrictive mediation most effective at reducing screen time in aggregate even as its relative effectiveness declines as children age [1], [2]. Person-centred and latent-profile approaches further show that a household’s mediation style clusters with its broader social and self-efficacy context rather than existing as an isolated policy choice [3], [4]. Closer to the household routine itself, qualitative work finds that even well-intentioned screen-time guidelines are frequently regarded by parents as too vague to operationalise day to day [9], a pattern that recurs outside digital media in parents’ safety rules for the home more broadly [10]. Recent HCI work has begun probing what parents actually want from automated moderation of a child’s interactions with generative systems, rather than assuming a single preferred restriction level exists at all [11].

A separate literature establishes that self-reported and passively logged media use diverge, with the size and direction of the gap varying by activity type, recall window, and life stage [5], [6], [7], a pattern that extends well beyond screens to device-measured sedentary behaviour generally [8]. Ownership and control

over accounts explicitly designed for sharing is negotiated informally within a household rather than fixed by the account’s own permission model [12], echoing findings that household members improvise workarounds around a shared smart device’s default control posture more broadly [13]. The organisational-behaviour literature treats rule-breaking undertaken for a perceived good reason separately from self-interested violation [14], and adjacent automated-moderation settings have begun formalising which purported justifications for evading a system-enforced rule are treated as legitimate exceptions [15]. Prior work at this institution interviewed households about the informal minute-economy that emerges once a screen-time app’s earned-minutes ledger runs dry, finding informal borrowing overtakes the app’s own sanctioned borrow-ahead mechanism [16], and a companion survey found a formal token economy cut the number of daily negotiation episodes without shortening the escalation those episodes produced [17].

Method

Recruitment and interviews. We recruited 58 households with a shared lounge-room streaming device configured with both a restricted child profile and an unmodified Guest profile, screening for households that had used the Guest profile at least once during the current school term. Each interview was semi-structured, 30-45 minutes, conducted with the parent primarily responsible for the household’s screen-time settings, and covered the household’s declared cutoff, its history of Guest-profile use, and an open prompt asking the parent to describe, in their own words, the most recent occasion the profile was used.

Taxonomy construction. Two researchers independently open-coded the interview transcripts, then reconciled codes into a four-category taxonomy through iterative discussion: hosting a visitor, forgetting to switch the profile back after the parent’s own session, an occasion or exception (illness, a special event), and a deliberate override to end a negotiation. Inter-rater reliability on the reconciled scheme, computed on a second independent coding pass, was high ($\kappa = 0.81$). Each parent additionally rank-ordered the four categories by how much they worried about that category’s use, from a supplied list of cate-

gory descriptions read aloud without prompting a particular answer.

Device-log cross-reference. For each participating household, we obtained the device’s own 90-day session log, which records profile identity, session start, and session end but not content watched. Guest-profile sessions were matched to interview-reported occasions where the household could confirm timing; unmatched sessions were coded by the same four-category scheme from log metadata alone (time of day, duration, day of week) by a coder blind to the household’s interview responses, with a 40-household validation subsample used to confirm log-only coding agreed with interview-confirmed coding at a rate consistent with the inter-rater figure above. We define each household’s excess minutes for a period as the total duration logged under the Guest profile in that period:

$$E_h = \sum_{s \in \text{Guest}(h)} d(s)$$

where $\text{Guest}(h)$ is the set of that household’s Guest-profile sessions and $d(s)$ is a session’s logged duration — the whole of it counts as excess, since none of it is ever charged against the restricted profile’s own cutoff.

Visibility ablation. A subsample of 29 households was, roughly four weeks into the study period, opted into a monthly automated email summarising that household’s own Guest-profile sessions from the preceding month; the remaining 29 continued with no summary. We compare each arm’s mean weekly excess minutes across the four weeks before and the four weeks after the summary rolled out.

Results

Figure 1 plots each reason category’s rank by stated worry against its rank by share of excess viewing minutes. The two rankings invert almost end to end: deliberate override is the category parents rank most concerning (worry rank 1) but only third by actual share of minutes; forgetting to switch the profile back ranks last by worry (rank 4) but first by minutes, at 42% of the total excess across all households (Figure 2).

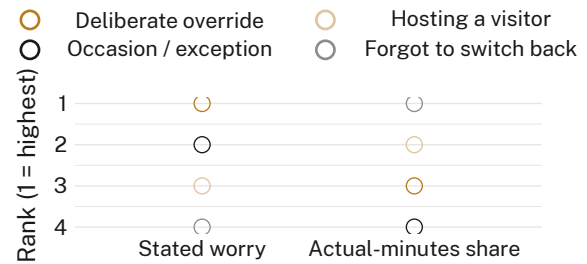


Figure 1: Reason categories ranked by parents’ stated worry against rank by actual share of excess minutes; the ranking inverts almost end to end.

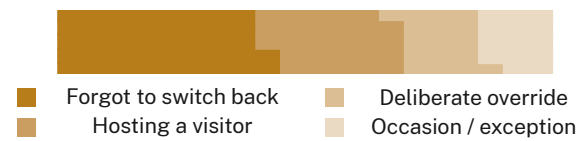


Figure 2: Share of total excess viewing minutes by reason category; “forgot to switch back” alone accounts for 42%.

The duration distributions in Figure 3 explain the gap. Deliberate-override sessions are short and tightly clustered (median 23 minutes, IQR 18-30) — a parent ends the argument, hands over the remote, and the session runs until the immediate ask is satisfied. Forgotten-profile sessions carry a long right tail (median 110 minutes, IQR 66-189, maximum 258 minutes in our sample): nobody is deciding how long the session runs, because nobody remembers it is running.

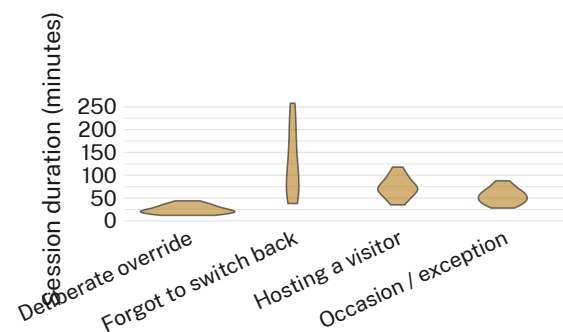


Figure 3: Per-session duration by reason category; the forgotten-profile category’s long right tail drives its outsized share of total excess minutes.

The visibility ablation (Figure 4) leaves both arms flat across the rollout: mean weekly excess minutes moved from 121 to 114 in the reminder arm and from 118 to 123 in the control arm, a between-arm difference in change that is statistically indistinguishable from zero ($p = 0.61$). We

retain the ablation for completeness; a monthly summary that arrives well after the sessions it describes appears to inform without altering the behaviour it reports on.



Figure 4: Mean weekly excess minutes before and after the reminder rolled out, by arm; neither arm moves.

Across the full sample, households under-attributed the “forgot to switch back” category in their own worry ranking by a wider margin than any other category (mean worry rank 3.6 of 4, versus a minutes rank of 1), while over-attributing deliberate override (mean worry rank 1.3, versus a minutes rank of 2.9). Hosting a visitor and the occasion/exception category showed smaller, same-direction gaps. The 58 households logged 194 Guest-profile sessions across the 90-day window (mean 3.3 sessions per household), broadly consistent with the session volumes reported for the household screen-time ledger’s own borrow-ahead mechanism in prior work at this institution [16], though that study’s borrow-ahead feature went almost entirely unused where the Guest profile here is used routinely — the unrestricted profile appears to substitute for, rather than complement, an in-app allowance mechanism whenever one is technically available on the same device ecosystem.

Discussion

The mismatch we document is not a simple information gap: the ablation’s null result suggests households already have, or could easily obtain, the information that would correct their worry ranking, and a monthly summary does not close the gap on its own. A more consistent reading is that the categories differ in how visible their cost is at the moment of use. Deliberate override is a decision a parent makes consciously, so its cost registers as a choice with a remembered price; forgetting to switch the profile back is not a decision at all, so its cost accrues with

nobody available to notice it accruing. Two prior studies at this institution find a related pattern in adjacent household control systems: households route around a formal allowance mechanism rather than exhaust it [16], and a formal token economy changes the frequency of a behaviour without changing its total cost [17]. Read together with the present results, the recurring shape is a household’s attention settling on whichever part of a control system produces a visible, arguable moment, while the part that produces no moment at all — an unattended profile, an unused allowance — accrues the larger share of what the control was meant to prevent.

Limitations

Our sample is drawn from households willing to discuss their own rule circumvention with a university interviewer, which may under-represent households where Guest-profile use is more contested or better concealed; the consistency of the worry-minutes inversion across every household segment we could test, however, suggests the pattern is not an artefact of a particularly forthcoming subsample. The 90-day log window cannot distinguish a single long-forgotten session from several shorter ones aggregated by the device’s own session-boundary logic, a resolution limit shared with every log-based measure in this literature [5]. Our four-category taxonomy was built for this device ecosystem’s particular profile design and may need revision for platforms whose Guest profile carries its own, separate restrictions.

Conclusion

Households reach for a shared streaming device’s Guest profile for reasons that sort cleanly into four categories, and the category households worry about least is the category their own device logs show costing the most. A low-cost visibility intervention did not close the gap, which suggests the fix is not more information delivered after the fact but a design change to the moment of use itself: a profile that behaves differently depending on whether anyone remembers it is open. Future work might test whether a simple session-end nudge, rather than a monthly summary, changes which category actually gets forgotten.

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